



Warming up: Craig Fulton, chief coach of the Indian men's hockey team, oversees a training session at the Sports Authority of India's Southern Centre in Bengaluru's Jnanabharathi campus. K. MURALI KUMAR

Authority of India (SAI), Bengaluru, before a preparatory tour in Western Australia. "We're in a good position now going into this tournament," Fulton said. "I think we've had a real focus on our physical conditioning. We've upped it in terms of being better prepared tactically."

Battleground Asia

For India, the Asia Cup has always been more than just another tournament — once a stage of near-misses, later a showcase of dominance, and now a proving ground with a World Cup spot at stake. Fulton must walk a tightrope: chasing gold, testing tactical innovations, and still keeping cards in hand for bigger battles ahead.

India's record against Asian rivals in recent years is daunting. The team scored 94 goals in 14 matches across the 2023 Asian Games and 2024 Asian Champions Trophy. But history warns

against complacency. The bronze at the 2022 Asia Cup was a sobering reminder that form can dip sharply after peaks.

No Pakistan, less sparkle

The absence of Pakistan dims the tournament's lustre. The rivalry remains the region's marquee attraction, even when the teams are unevenly matched. Following the Pahalgam terror attack and heightened military tensions, Pakistan declined its invitation, despite India's promise of visas, citing security concerns. The Asian Hockey Federation turned to Bangladesh to fill the void. India now faces China, Japan, and Kazakhstan (a late replacement for Oman) in Pool A. Pool B features Malaysia, Korea, Chinese Taipei, and Bangladesh. The tournament opens on August 29, with Malaysia facing Bangladesh, followed by defending champion Korea

against Chinese Taipei, before India launches its campaign against China.

Host factor

The Asia Cup also marks the men's first major outing in Bihar. After Rajgir's successful staging of the Women's Asian Champions Trophy, excitement is palpable.

"We're absolutely thrilled to be playing in Rajgir," said veteran midfielder Manpreet Singh. "It's fantastic to see more states building world-class infrastructure for international hockey. The girls told us all about the incredible local support they received during the ACT. We can't wait to get out there and give them our best game."

With a World Cup berth and continental supremacy on the line, India has little margin for error. Anything less than victory could trigger uncomfortable questions about both strategy and leadership.



Men's schedule

Friday, 29 August 2025

M01 - 09:00 - Pool B - Malaysia v Bangladesh
M02 - 11:00 - Pool B - Korea v Chinese Taipei
M03 - 13:00 - Pool A - Japan v Kazakhstan
M04 - 15:00 - Pool A - India v China

Saturday, 30 August 2025

M05 - 13:00 - Pool B - Bangladesh v Chinese Taipei
M06 - 15:00 - Pool B - Korea v Malaysia

Sunday, 31 August 2025

M07 - 13:00 - Pool A - China v Kazakhstan
M08 - 15:00 - Pool A - Japan v India

Monday, 1 September 2025

M09 - 13:30 - Pool B - Bangladesh v Korea
M10 - 15:30 - Pool B - Malaysia v Chinese Taipei
M11 - 17:30 - Pool A China v Japan
M12 - 19:30 - Pool A - India v Kazakhstan

Wednesday, 3 September 2025

M13 - 14:30 - 5/8th Place - 3rd Pool A v 4th Pool B
M14 - 17:00 - Super4s Pool - TBC v TBC
M18 - 19:30 - Super4s Pool - TBC v TBC

Saturday, 6 September 2025

M19 - 14:30 - 7/8th Place - Loser M13 v Loser M16
M20 - 17:00 - Super4s Pool - TBC v TBC
M21 - 19:30 - Super4s Pool - TBC v TBC

Sunday, 7 September 2025

M22 - 14:30 - 5/6th Place - Winner M13 v Winner M16
M23 - 17:00 - 3/4th Place - 3rd Super4s Pool v 4th Super4s Pool
M24 - 19:30 - Final - 1st Super4s Pool v 2nd Super4s Pool